

Class Questions

THE GENDER LENS SERIES

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The Gender Lens Series has been conceptualized as a way of encouraging the development of a sociological understanding of gender. A "gender lens" means working to make gender visible in social phenomena, asking if, how, and why social processes, standards, and opportunities differ systematically for women and men. It also means recognizing that gender inequality is inextricably braided with other systems of inequality. The Gender Lens Series is committed to social change directed toward eradicating these inequalities. Originally published by Sage Publications and Pine Forge Press, all Gender Lens books are now available from AltaMira Press and Rowman and Littlefield Publishers, Inc.

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Class Questions

Feminist Answers

Joan Acker

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Preface

In this book, I present my views on some long-standing feminist conceptual issues, building on the work of many others. Thus, my first thanks go to all whose thinking and writing about class, gender, race, and organizations made this contribution possible. Dorothy Smith is the one most immediately responsible for my writing this book. She insisted that I publish a collection of my essays, leading me to expand and develop the ideas in those essays into a book on gendered and racialized class. I also owe Dorothy much gratitude for her ideas that have so influenced me and for her friendship. Other friends who have been my co-researchers have contributed a great deal to my knowledge: Don Van Houten for his work with me on organizations, including much of the analysis in chapter 5 of this book; Margaret Hallock for all she taught me about unions and organizations as we tried to establish comparable worth in Oregon; Johanna Esseveld and Kate Barry for their critiques and discussions beginning in a project we did together long ago; Sandi Morgen for her partnership in studying welfare restructuring and many other projects. Thank you all for your excellent friendships and ideas. Many other friends have contributed to my thinking, including Cynthia Cockburn, Barbara Czarniawska, Nona Glazer, Harriet Holter, Wuokko Knocke, Elin Kvande, Arnlaug Leira, Judith Lorber, Patricia Martin, Carole Pateman, Frances Fox Piven, Bente Rasmussen, and Karin Widerberg. I also thank Joey Sprague for guiding me and this book through the process of writing and publishing, as well as Heidi Gottfried and Bill Martin for very helpful reviews of the manuscript. And thanks to the rest of the Gender Lens group, Judy Howard, Barbara Risman, and Mitch Allen, for all your help and support. Finally, thanks to Alan McClare, Alex Masulis, Jessica Gribble, and Marian Haggard at Rowman & Littlefield who turned my manuscript into a real book.

Series Editors' Foreword

It is now more than twenty years since feminist sociologists identified gender as an important analytic dimension in sociology. In the intervening decades, theory and research on gender have grown exponentially. With this series, we intend to further this scholarship, as well as ensure that theory and research on gender become fully integrated into the discipline as a whole.

In their classic edited collection *Analyzing Gender: A Handbook of Social Science Research* (1987), Beth Hess and Myra Marx Ferree identify three stages in the study of women and men since 1970. Initially, the emphasis was on sex differences and the extent to which such differences might be based on the biological properties of individuals. In the second stage, the focus shifted to the individual sex roles and socialization, exposing gender as the product of specific social arrangements, although still conceptualizing it as an individual trait. The hallmark of the third stage is the recognition of the centrality of gender as an organizing principle in all social systems, including work, politics, everyday interaction, families, economic development, law, education, and a host of other social domains. As our understanding of gender has become more social, so has our awareness that gender is experience and organized in race- and class-specific ways.

In the summer of 1992, the American Sociological Association (ASA) funded a small conference organized by Barbara Risman and Joey Sprague to discuss the evolution of gender in these distinctly sociological frameworks. The conference brought together a sampling of gender scholars working in a range of substantive areas with a diversity of methods to focus on gender as a principle of social organization. The discussions of the state of feminist scholarship made it clear that gender is pervasive in society and operates at multiple levels. Gender shapes identities and perception, interactional practices, and the very forms of social

institutions, and it does so in race- and class-specific ways. If we did not see gender in social phenomena, we were not seeing them clearly.

The participants in the ASA-sponsored seminar recognized that although these developing ideas about gender were widely accepted by feminist sociologists and many others who study social inequalities, they were relatively unfamiliar to many who work within other sociological paradigms. This book series was conceived at that conference as a means of introducing these ideas to sociological colleagues and students and of helping to develop gender scholarship further.

As series editors, we believe it is time for gender scholars to speak to our other colleagues and to the general education of students. There are many sociologists and scholars in other social sciences who want to incorporate scholarship on gender and its intersections with race, class, and sexuality in their teaching and research but lack the tools to do so. For those who have not worked in this area, the prospect of the bibliographic research necessary to develop supplementary units or transform their own teaching and scholarship is daunting. Moreover, the publications necessary to penetrate a curriculum resistant to change and encumbered by inertia have simply not been available. We conceptualize this book series as a way of meeting the needs of these scholars and thereby also encouraging the development of the sociological understanding of gender by offering a "gender lens."

What do we mean by a *gender lens*? We mean working to make gender visible in social phenomena, asking if, how, and why social processes, standards, and opportunities differ systematically in women and men. We also mean recognizing that gender inequality is inextricably intertwined with other systems of inequality. Looking at the world through a gendered lens thus implies two seemingly contradictory tasks. First, it means unpacking the assumptions about gender that pervade sociological research and social life in general. At the same time, looking through a gender lens means revealing how central assumptions about gender continue to be the organization of the social world, regardless of their empirical reality. We show how our often unquestioned ideas about gender affect the words we use, the questions we ask, the answers we envision. The Gender Lens Series is committed to social change directed toward eradicating these inequalities. Our goals are consistent with initiatives at colleges and universities across the United States that are encouraging the development of more diverse scholarship and teaching.

The books in the Gender Lens Series are aimed at different audiences and have been written for a variety of uses, from assigned readings in introductory undergraduate courses to graduate seminars and as professional resources for our colleagues. The series includes several different styles of books that address these goals in distinct ways. We are excited

about the series and anticipate that it will have an enduring impact on the direction of both the pedagogy and the scholarship in sociology and other related social sciences. We invite you, the reader, to join us in thinking through these difficult but exciting issues by offering feedback or by developing your own project and proposing it for use in the series.

ABOUT THIS VOLUME

Class questions is an urgent task at the beginning of the twenty-first century as global, national, and local inequalities escalate. Yet conventional conceptualizations of class are inadequate to the task because they illuminate the economic experiences of white men more clearly than those of white women or people of color. In this book, Joan Acker sounds the call for a return to questions of class while she deftly articulates a carefully reasoned resolution to the conceptualization problem. Acker proposes that we see class and capitalism as fundamentally gendered and racialized and powerfully shaped in work organizations.

Acker examines the efforts of feminist theorists, beginning in the late 1960s, to create theories of capitalism and class, or patriarchy and capitalism, as well as more recent efforts to integrate gender into class theory, to theorize the intersectionality of gender, race, and class, and to use other innovative approaches to account for the ongoing creation of gender and racial/ethnic differences within economic processes. She finds that attempts to integrate gender into class theories and to theorize the intersection of separate gender, race, and class structures both run into conceptual difficulties that can be resolved by analyzing class itself as thoroughly gendered and racialized.

Analyses of gendered and racialized class, Acker argues, must be based on concrete practices, not abstract structures, and on an expanded idea of the economy suggested by other feminist scholars that includes unpaid work and family forms of distribution. A feminist concept of gendered and racialized class relations spans production, reproduction, and distribution and includes the invisible work of linking households and paid workplaces.

Acker shows how capitalism was gendered and racialized historically, as it evolved in a process dominated by small groups of white men, and legitimated with images of masculinity. This process differed in various industrializing countries: the focus here is the United States. The subordination of white women, differing in various class situations, and the exploitation and enslavement of people of other race/ethnic groups were built into U.S. capitalism from the beginning. Capitalism developed with a gendered understructure anchored in divisions between the aims and

organization of production and reproduction: production was organized to achieve profit, not to provide for and care for children and families. As women had the bulk of caring responsibilities, this was a gendered organization of necessary work.

With reproductive work relegated to women in the household, capitalist organizations could claim nonresponsibility for human reproduction, and nonresponsibility for the environment as well. Thus, capitalist claims to *nonresponsibility* are built into the basic aims of capitalist organizations and into society-wide gender and racial divisions of labor. The vast power of capitalist organizations in a highly monetized society, along with their nonresponsibility, continues to contribute to the devaluation of caring work and the women who do most of it. Such devaluation is central to women's class situations. Racial inequality and subordination are attributed to individual or group failings, thus are also outside the realm of corporate organizational responsibility.

Next Acker turns to the roles of powerful organizations and organizational actors in shaping gendered and racialized class. Organizations are the sites in which gendered and racialized class relations are created as integral to the ordinary business of getting the work done, accounting for the costs and revenues, hiring and firing, and setting wages. Acker examines these processes in greater detail, developing the concept of "inequality regimes." An inequality regime is the configuration of inequality-producing practices and processes within particular organizations at particular times. Class inequality is more legitimate than racial and gender inequality in the United States. This legitimacy of class and the strength of white, male gendered and racialized class interests often undermine efforts at organizational change, such as affirmative action, pay equity, and diversity projects.

Finally, Acker examines contemporary changes in work and employment in local, national, and global economic/political processes that are increasing inequalities and altering racialized and gendered class relations. Capitalist organizational processes have led to large-scale changes in the organization of production, the decline of manufacturing jobs, and the increase in service sector jobs. These changes have had gendered and racialized impacts. Changing work practices and employment contracts, facilitated by employer attacks on unions, have made work less secure for many. Gendered and racialized class patterns become more polarized as income and wealth inequality also increase and tax reductions favor corporations and the wealthy. These changes, plus the downsizing of the social safety net, mean that those already with poorer jobs and lower wages fall further behind. With so many women doing paid work, new questions emerge such as whether the male-breadwinner-family is a

thing of the past and how people deal with the tasks of bridging family and work demands.

Changes are ongoing, Acker reminds us: white-collar and professional jobs are increasingly being moved offshore and Wal-Mart has emerged as the model of profitable organization. Both of these changes could mean further, serious alterations in gendered and racialized class configurations in the United States. Acker concludes by considering the implications of her conceptualization of class for progressive social change, outlining some proposals for decreasing gendered and racialized class inequalities.

Class questions are vital and immediate. In this book, Joan Acker develops an innovative and exciting feminist response that will change the way the reader understands how we got to this point and how we can most effectively respond to the challenges we face in the twenty-first century economy.

Judith A. Howard
Barbara Risman
Joey Sprague

Introduction—The Feminist Problem with Class

“Class matters” (hooks 2000; Phillips 1987; Wright 1997b) at the beginning of the twenty-first century. New class inequalities are arising from global, national, and local changes in capitalist production and politics, altering the daily lives of ordinary people in cross-cutting and contradicting patterns of gender, race, ethnicity, class, and nation. But, the concept of class is problematic. As some feminist scholars have argued, this concept illuminates the economic experiences of white men more clearly than those of white women or people of color because it was developed primarily within a privileged white male perspective. Exactly how class matters for white women and people of other racial groups is still an issue. In this book I examine feminist attempts to imagine a concept of class that resolves problems of combining gender, race, and class, and I argue for a concept of class as gendered and racialized as a solution. I also argue that class relations include not only relations of production and paid labor, but also relations of distribution and unpaid labor. I discuss gendered and racialized class processes and practices as fundamental in the emergence and ongoing structuring of various capitalisms, and as intrinsic to organizational processes. Finally, I examine some contemporary changes in work and employment and in local, national, and global economic/political processes that seem to be increasing inequalities and altering racialized and gendered class relations.

Class is a particularly important idea at the beginning of the twenty-first century as the bursting of the economic bubble of the late 1990s has severely undermined illusions in rich capitalist countries that everyone is becoming affluent. In other, less rich countries, extreme poverty is the fate for very large numbers of people. “Globalization,” economic restructur-

ing, and new technology continue to transform daily lives in many nations in multiple and widely different ways, sometimes for the better but often for the worse. Economic inequality is growing within nations and, globally, between nations. While those in the upper reaches of class structures enjoy incredible luxury, those at the bottom struggle to feed their families and may be hungry or even starving. In industrialized countries, class divisions between women are becoming greater as more and more women become paid workers, and some women enter well-paid professional and managerial jobs while a majority of women remain in low-paid “women’s” jobs. Class divisions between men also become greater as some men direct large and increasingly powerful organizations in both public and private sectors, while many other men are unable to find work that pays a “family wage” as highly paid, secure production jobs disappear. At the same time, welfare state protections for single parent families, the unemployed, the destitute, the elderly, and the ill have been seriously undermined, particularly in the United States. These and many other transformations are visible evidences of political and economic processes in contemporary capitalism. “Class” is a central concept for comprehending these processes, although what is precisely meant by the term varies enormously.

Beginning with Marx and Weber, “class” has been at the center of efforts to understand systematic and systemic inequalities within capitalist societies. Class, as the concept that locates groups and individuals within ongoing capitalist processes, is essential for understanding gender and racial/ethnic differences in poverty and discrimination, and political/economic conflict around these issues, as well as issues of identity and consciousness. “Class” points to the economic realities which women and men of all racial and ethnic groups must contend with, whether they are living in rich capitalist countries, in countries still making a transition from socialism to capitalism, in not-so-rich countries, or in impoverished countries in the rest of the world. Thus, it is also an essential concept for understanding differences between peoples in varying global situations and the links across the boundaries of those situations.

Class, although essential for making sense of the contemporary world, is a highly contested concept and a curiously vulnerable idea, subject to reassessment as political climates and work structuring change. In the 1970s and 1980s, mainstream class theorists debated class theories, arguing about class consciousness, class formation, the possibilities of class action with the rapidly changing composition of the labor force, and whether relations of production or market relations were the best way to formulate the economic processes producing class structures. They also debated the merits of structural class analyses versus historical analyses.

Most male theorists ignored the question of women and gender. Thus, the feminist and nonfeminist discourses on class rarely intersected.

Mainstream sociologists and political theorists in the United States and in Britain, depending to a degree on their theoretical allegiances, have repeatedly proclaimed that class is dead or at least seriously ill (Crompton and Scott 2000). Such proclamations have usually been based on the decline of industrial working class employment in rich capitalist nations and diminishing union membership along with minimal success in working class mobilization. But, class survives. At the end of the twentieth century and the beginning of the twenty-first, new books and journal debates on class and class theory are again appearing (Baxter and Western 2001; Crompton, Devine, Savage, and Scott 2000; Hall 1997; Portes 2000),¹ reaffirming the relevance of class. Many of these discussions of class are little affected or disturbed by feminist critiques, as they continue to use notions of class and class processes that assume gender and race neutrality. Some, however, recognize that gender and race are important in understanding class, although they do not do much to bring that recognition into their analyses.

The history of feminist thinking about class shows a different pattern. Some feminists inside and outside academia criticized established, male-centered analyses of class at the beginning of Second Wave feminism. They argued that these analyses could not account for women's exploitation and inequality that was different from and more severe in its consequences than the exploitation and inequality suffered by working class men. Socialist and Marxist feminists, in particular, had intense debates on women, patriarchy, class, and gender from the late 1960s into the 1980s, criticizing concepts of class that made women invisible and proposing new approaches.² However, as solutions to conceptual and theoretical problems proved to be elusive, feminist debates about class almost disappeared. A few sociologists, anthropologists, and others (e.g., Acker 2000; Pollert 1996; Glucksmann 1995; Gottfried 1998) made new attempts to theorize gender and class, even as much attention moved away from class to issues of identity, diversity, race, discourse, and sexuality. Thus, class never completely evaporated from feminist scholarship and writing. In addition, a great deal of empirical work continues to be done on related issues such as sex segregation, wage inequalities, gender relations in work organizations, gendered effects of economy and production restructuring, and work-family connections, but theoretical issues having to do with economic relations were submerged as questions of culture and identity became more interesting. "Class" was no longer cutting edge.

As black and Third World feminists began in the 1970s to criticize feminist thinking for its location in a white, middle class consciousness that limited understanding of the lives of "others" (hooks 1984; Davis 1981;

Dill 1979; Collins 1990; Spelman 1989), many white feminist academics began to try to talk about race, gender, and class. I emphasize “try” because good intentions did not always result in substantial changes. The unmarked subject position of “whiteness” persists in a great deal of writing. Although white scholars began to recognize the necessity of understanding race as important in the structuring of class, in practice race was usually absent or a token presence along with sexuality in their analyses. These efforts to integrate gender, race, and class have revealed again how racial privileging along with the conventions of sociological theorizing about systems, structures, and levels still constrain efforts to rethink social life from perspectives of women located outside the “relations of ruling” (Smith 1999). The “race, gender, and class” discourses invented the notion of intersectionality, opening new ways of seeing how power, oppression, exploitation, and inequality work. However, these efforts to reconceptualize have, on the whole, paid little attention to what they mean by “class.” They have not resolved the issue of how to think about class in ways that encompass the material/economic situations of women variously located in capitalist societies.

Now, feminist debates about class seem to be beginning again. bell hooks (2000) argues that “class matters” because, in her view, class has receded to the background in much feminist writing in the last ten years or so. She affirms the importance of class in her own life and in the lives of millions of other people who exist within growing insecurity and inequality. Nancy Fraser (1997), in a different feminist discourse, argues that a political and intellectual divide between redistribution (class) and recognition (culture/identity) must be bridged to develop a progressive politic of the future in a “postsocialist” world. To do this, she engages with “class” in arguments about types of remedies for injustices of distribution and recognition. Both hooks and Fraser bring our attention back to class, but without revisiting the earlier and unresolved feminist criticisms of class.

The same may be said for many feminist sociologists and other social scientists. Feminist scholars in the United States agree that gender, race, and class domination are intrinsically linked (Acker 2000; Collins 2000; hooks 2000; Weber 2001), but the “class” that enters that linkage is often unexamined, and is often some version of the same old, unreconstructed “class.” An additional problem confronting these efforts to think about complex inequalities is how to specify what is meant by “intrinsically linked” or “intersectionality,” how to see linkages in ways that do not ultimately give class or race or gender a privileged position as the most important element in understanding power and oppression. I think it is possible that solving those issues depends on solving the problems of “class.” These problems are:

- Conceptualizing class and capitalism as gender- and race-neutral structures or processes, while implicitly modeling the class actor on a male worker or capitalist.
- Defining the capitalist economy, the basis of class, as encompassing only market-related activities, thus ignoring unpaid, reproductive, and subsistence work as economic and also basic to class.
- Ignoring the importance of state and family distributions for class relations.
- Failing to recognize the importance of masculine and white privilege in the historical development and contemporary functioning of class relations, as well as the importance of hegemonic masculinities in supporting exploitation and domination.

In this book, I present some solutions to these problems, using the scholarly work of others from the early (late 1960s and early 1970s) socialist feminist and Marxist feminist debates to the postcolonial feminist discourses of the beginning of the twenty-first century. I also use my own work on women, gender, and class, which began with an article in 1973. I build on the insights of the 1980s (e.g., Acker 1988; Phillips 1987) that class relations are always gendered and are constructed through gender. I also rely on my research on work and women for understanding and examples. This research includes a study of housewives attempting to return to work, a participatory study of a comparable worth project, a study of female bank workers in Sweden, a study of organizational restructuring in a college, and a study of welfare restructuring in the late 1990s. I learned a great deal from all these studies, including something of the complexity of the class relations within which the women (and men) were enmeshed, and how class, gender, and race are produced in work organizations. My sometimes abstract discussions are always informed by these realities, or so I hope. I next offer preliminary definitions of gender, race, and class. I end this introduction with a brief outline of my argument about how to resolve the issues listed above as it is developed in the following chapters.

Defining class, race, and gender. Class, race, and gender are conceptual categories, variously defined and debated from different theoretical perspectives. These words are often used as nouns, but such usage reifies processes and practices that are continually bringing into existence the situations, images, conditions, and relations that the words intend (Acker 1992a). I prefer verbal forms, such as gendering, or adjectival forms, such as racialized, that better capture the sense of process and diversity. Certain definitions are more amenable to an analysis of mutually constituting processes than are others.

Gender is best understood as pervasive patterns of difference, in advan-

tage and disadvantage, work and reward, emotion and sexuality, image and identity, between female and male, created through practical activities and representations that justify these patterns that result in the social categories of women and men. Gender may include more than these two categories. Gender is a basic principle of social organization, almost always involving unequal economic and social power in which men dominate. Gender is socially constructed and diverse, and varies historically and cross-culturally.

Race is also socially and politically constructed around definitions of skin color and other physical characteristics; in particular, historical processes of war, colonization, slavery, immigration, and migration (for example, hooks 1981, 1984; Collins 2000; Bhavnani 2001; Glenn 2002). Race, too, almost always involves inequalities of power and material resources, resulting from and constituting relations of domination, exclusion, and exploitation. Racial representations in white society are primary ideological justifications for systematic exploitation and subordination. Historically, many different racial categories and identities have emerged, with members of the category "white" almost always in dominant positions in the northern industrial countries. Race, too, can be seen as a basic principle of social organization. Ethnicity differs from race, but is often associated with race. Ethnic differences are based on cultural and language traditions and do not always involve inequalities.

Class generally stands for economic/power inequalities structured by production, market, and/or occupational systems. Definitions of class, in my view, are more problematic than those of race and gender because the feminist critique of class theories did not lead to new feminist theories. Thus, certain conceptual problems remained unsolved: the invisibility of gender (and race) in class theories and the implicit male model of the class actor. Available class theories include structural Marxist approaches that specify some core set of class relations embedded in capitalist structures (e.g., Wright 2001a), historical materialist theories that emphasize economic structural change, class consciousness, and class conflict (e.g., Thompson 1963), Marxist theories of the labor process (e.g., Burawoy 1979), Weberian theories of class and status (e.g., Giddens 1973), occupational categorical schemes (e.g., Goldthorpe 1980), and relatively untheorized notions of positions in the economy related to income and wealth, such as lower class, working class, middle class, and upper class. I think that a feminist historical materialist approach, evident in much feminist historical and ethnographic work, holds the most promise for a class analysis that is compatible with the above concepts of gender and race. Below I outline the components of such an approach to a gendered and racialized class analysis, arguing that class is also socially constructed and processual, the outcome or effect of practices and relations that constitute

the production and distribution of the means of survival. Class is, of course, a basic principle of social organization in capitalist societies.

Combining race, gender, and class. In pursuing an approach to class that displaces the white male model I have tried to develop the insights that class and capitalism are gendered, adding that class and capitalism are also racialized (see Omi and Winant 1994, 68). This way of combining gender, race, and class is different from arguing for intersections between systems or structures with their own, preexisting internal elements and dynamics. Rather than already existing, distinct systems, I see ongoing processes and practices in which gendering and racialization are integral to the creation and recreation of class inequalities and class divisions, emerging in complex, multifaceted, boundary-spanning capitalist activities. This is only one way to look at gender, race, and class. It is also partial, with a focus more on work relations than on other areas of daily life in which race, class, and gender also structure participation, inequality, and interpretation.³ For example, I do not discuss how material and cultural consumption practices express and create gendered and racialized class distinctions and identities. I give little space to other important class processes, such as those in our schools, colleges, and universities. Lacking infinite space, I had to make choices about emphasis and inclusion of topics, and I chose to emphasize work and distribution in the following discussion.

In chapter 2, I discuss attempts to bring women into class analysis by both white feminist and nonfeminist class theorists. Most of these theoretical and empirical studies did not include race and racial inequalities. Other discussions and studies by women of color looked at race and its intersections with gender and class. General agreement emerged among all these scholars that gender and class, and then race, should be understood as mutually constituted and studied as lived experience or as practices in historically specific contexts. Some argued that reproduction and unpaid labor should be included in concepts of class relations. Problems remained in how to include reproduction and unpaid labor in understanding class practices and in how to give concrete meaning to metaphors such as "intersections" or "mutually constituting." This discussion of theorizing provides the basis for the ensuing chapters.

In chapter 3, I first discuss conceptual approaches to resolving some of the difficulties in thinking about class, gender, and race that were discussed in chapter 2. Thinking about the social as activities and practices is a basic step toward conceptualizing gendered and racialized class relations.⁴ Embodied people engage in, coordinate, and interpret the practices of daily life within gendered and racialized distributions of power and inequality. Extended social relations, originating outside local places and specifying local practices, link those local practices into distant social

spaces. What is often called “social structure,” including class, gender, and race, is emergent in practices, produced and reproduced in ongoing human activities. Thus, people are not located in class structures, but enmeshed in class relations. To understand the complexity and variety of gendered and racialized class processes, investigations can begin in the standpoints of a variety of people who are enmeshed in class relations in different ways. To clarify the meaning of “gendered and racialized,” investigations can look at how class experiences differ for white women, women and men of color, and white men, and how differences and persistent inequalities are explained and justified. To bring women of all races into class analysis, the notion of what counts as “economic” must be expanded to include unpaid work and other forms of unrecognized work. To expand the economic, I adopt economist Julie Nelson’s (1993) concept of economic activity as processes of provisioning, providing what is socially defined as necessary to sustain life and ensure survival.

In the remainder of chapter 3, I outline the class practices and relations that accomplish provisioning. These include relations of paid and unpaid production and reproduction, relations of distribution, and relations that link paid work and unpaid family work. Class relations take place in the production of goods and services, both very broadly defined, and in the distribution of wages, taxes, and profits generated in production. Distribution is embedded in different forms of relations, including personal and intimate ties and impersonal, bureaucratic processes. Distribution through marriage and family relations is one way in which personal, emotional life is implicated in class relations. Linking activities create the infrastructure of scheduling, housework, and care of self and others that make it possible to be a paid worker. Thus, class relations are also produced and reproduced outside what are thought of as core capitalist processes, in unpaid work of various kinds. Class processes are gendered and racialized through many concrete practices that are based on assumptions about gender and race differences and inequalities, reproducing images and ideologies that support different outcomes and shaping interactions and identities. This chapter concludes with an outline of a conceptual approach to gendered and racialized class processes.

In chapter 4, I argue that capitalisms are gendered and racialized. I use the plural, capitalisms, because important national historical differences exist in the ways in which capitalism incorporated gendered and racialized practices and ideologies. As industrial capitalism emerged in Britain and the United States in the nineteenth century, differences in the aims and activities of production and household reproduction developed. Capitalist firms organized to achieve profits; families and households organized to provide for survival, raise children, and create a satisfactory daily life. Contradictions between these two modes of work organization were

and are frequent. They were necessary to each other, but production often undermined the possibilities for survival, for example by paying wages too low to support a family. As many have argued, this was a gendered division. A relatively small group of white men drove the development of capitalist production, reworking forms of male domination as intrinsic to emerging class relations, and organizing the new factories and, later, the new offices based on assumptions about the masculine individual as the normal human being. Money and power were increasingly centralized in this male domain, while women were at least symbolically consigned to the domain with little power and money. Racial subordination, exploitation, and exclusion were also intrinsic to developing capitalism in the United States, providing a source of unpaid labor and, later, very low-wage labor based on racism and physical violence. White male workers accepted their dependence on wage labor partly through constructing their identities as different from and superior to women and African-American men.

Thus, white masculinity was central in the development of U.S. capitalism. As capitalist labor markets and wage practices became widespread and then bureaucratized, these were segregated and defined by gender and racial difference. These inequality processes, I argue, are also intrinsic to capitalist organizing. Although gender and race segregation and wage inequality have become less extreme, neither is disappearing, and instances of new forms of inequality and segregation are found in the "new economy."

Claims to corporate nonresponsibility for human and environmental survival and well-being, unless these goals happen to enhance profit, are an additional aspect of the gendering and racialization of capitalism. Claims to nonresponsibility are undergirded by the gendered separation between the aims of production and household reproduction. Such claims are particularly vociferous in the United States because of the dominance of neoliberal ideology in the last twenty-five years and the success of various capitalist organizations in fighting labor unions and achieving downsizing of both state and corporate welfare. Corporate nonresponsibility continually reinforces the responsibility of households, and mostly women within households, for survival and caring work. This is a process that pushes responsibility away from the centers of wealth and power and by implication devalues those who have little wealth and power but who must take on responsibility to preserve their lives and the lives of those around them. Women from poor and minority groups often have the greatest responsibilities and the fewest resources. These are both material and ideological processes that enshrine gender (male) and race (white) within capitalist organizing. Many white working class and middle class men have also been negatively affected by corporate nonresponsibility.

But, nonresponsibility is still based in the separations between the gendered organizing of production and the household and legitimated through laws and conventional practices that declare the private corporation to be a single-minded individual bent on getting the best deal in the market. Sometimes under pressure from reformers or social movements, governments attempt to control nonresponsibility with laws and regulations, with varying degrees of success. However, in the United States at least, the claims are continuously made and continuously countered, with a scarcely noticed gendered subtext to the arguments.

Chapter 5 deals with the role of work organizations in the structuring of gendered and racialized class processes. Powerful organizations and organizational actors, who are primarily white men, are central in the economic and political decision making that shapes class locally, nationally, and internationally. These actions maintain organizations' nonresponsibility, locate and relocate industries, and restructure jobs and workplaces. Large organizations control much of the media, and in other ways shape class processes. Organizations are also the sites in which gendered and racialized class relations are created as integral to the ordinary business of getting the work done, accounting for the costs and revenues, hiring and firing, and setting wages. I examine these processes in greater detail, developing the concept of "inequality regimes." An inequality regime is the configuration of inequality-producing practices and processes within particular organizations at particular times. Although common patterns exist, for example, in highly bureaucratic organizations, there are also many variations. Widespread attempts to restructure organizations, downsize management, and reorganize work in the last twenty years of the twentieth century and the first years of the twenty-first century contribute to variation. An inequality regime has a number of interconnected dimensions:

- The bases of inequality that may include, in addition to gender, race, and class, inequalities based on sexual orientation, age, differing abilities, and the like.
- Organizing practices that maintain inequalities, including hiring, job design, wage setting, and expectations about job performance based on a model of the worker as undistracted by outside obligations. Vertical and horizontal race- and gender-based segregation of jobs and positions, as well as functional segregation on the basis of race and gender, are produced and maintained through managerial and supervisory practices.
- The visibility and legitimacy of inequalities. Class inequality is much more legitimate than either race or gender inequality, but it may be more invisible because it is so widely accepted. Inequalities are legiti-